

gages need far less pruning than apples or pears (see tip box, left). Freestanding trees may not require pruning at all.

Fruits may need thinning out if growth is heavy (see image, left), to encourage larger fruits to form. Some crops will fall in early summer in the “June drop.” Thin out any remaining fruits to leave around 2–5 in (5–10 cm) between them.

HARVESTING

Plums and gages should be ready to harvest in midsummer; damsons in midfall. Leave plums that you plan to eat to ripen on the tree, and squeeze them gently to test—when they are soft to the touch they are ready to pick. Plums to be used for cooking can be harvested earlier and will keep a little longer in the refrigerator. Pick plums with a short amount of stalk attached to prevent the fruit skins from tearing. Fruits ripen in succession, so keep checking the tree for those that are ripe.

STORING

Plums, damsons, and gages will keep for a short time in the refrigerator, but try to use them as soon as possible after harvesting to keep them from spoiling.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Wasps, flies, and birds are drawn to sweet, ripening fruits, so do all you can to discourage them. Try to ensure that trees receive a constant level of moisture, since irregular watering can cause the plums’ skins to split, leaving them open to attack from both pests and diseases, notably brown rot, which will shrivel plums, covering the skins in spores. Net container-grown or wall-trained trees to deter birds.

Winter moths can be a real problem, and will munch their way through leaves—attach sticky grease bands around the trunks of trees and pick off any caterpillars you find. If aphids are a problem, spray with insecticidal soap. Be wary of diseases such as bacterial canker, plum sawfly, plum fruit moth, and pocket plum as well.



Wasps will feast on sweet, ripe fruits (left), so set up a jam-trap to distract them. Bacterial canker (right) creates holes in, and then withers, leaves.